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Duncan Gallie

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

2018

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

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Duncan Gallie

Interviewed by Paul Thompson

5, 6 February 2018

1: A Flying Academic Start

DG: Well, my father was an academic. He was a philosophy teacher in Wadham College, but I didn't know him very much because he died when I was two… Until the age of nine, she was a single mother…

So my mother came from, also from an academic background. Her father was a person called Robert Peers [1888-1972], who, he became Professor of Adult Education, in what was then the University College of Nottingham, in 1922. I'm told that this was the first Department of Adult Education in the country, University Department. But I didn't see much of him either, because he had quarrelled with my mother about marrying my father, because he thought it was really a very bad thing to be marrying some sort of Oxford academic doing philosophy – not a serious way of living your life! So they'd broken their relations till then, it was only when my mother remarried when I was nine, that I first saw this public figure who founded Adult Education! But then there was that interesting sort of contrast. He was, in some sense my mother was always talking about my father and his philosophy, but on the other hand there was this figure lurking in the background who was taking a rather different view about this abstract, and believed everyone should be doing public service, and one's work should be making some sort of impact on things. And the other point, the other part of the story was that my mother met my father here in Oxford. She was a student of his, [taking tutorials at] Wadham, when she was doing PPE at Somerville. …

PT: And your stepfather, did you talk with him?

DG: Not that much. He was a civil servant in the Department of Education. He became an Under Secretary in the Department of Education, and that's why he actually brought back my grandfather because he was able to open up access in the Department of Education to all the records my grandfather needed to write his final book on adult education. So he reconciled parts of the family, which was interesting.

PT: So your grandfather you did know, though?

DG: I knew him from the age of nine, yes. Yes. He was an irascible sort of character. He was one of these figures that I think may have been more common in those days, a very very good public servant, very socially minded, who was impossible domestically, I mean, absolutely authoritarian in a rather aggressive [way] and, so I didn't take to him very much. He was always a person that I preferred not to see, but I had great respect for him. But I think probably the conceptions of being a father and being a man were rather different in that generation. This must be much more your field!

PT: No, it's very interesting how they've changed. Definitely, yes. Well, it sounds like a flying start into intellectual life!

DG: Well, to have a dead father and an absent grandfather, yes! But like two ghosts.

PT: Very interesting. So there's no-one else in the family that's significant?

DG: Well, I also had an absent uncle, who was W. B. Gallie who was a philosopher, who became a Professor of Philosophy – actually in Cambridge, eventually. Initially, I think he was at Keele, he went with A.E. Lindsay in the foundation of Keele University, and then he spent some time as Professor of Philosophy in Belfast, and then he came back, oh, when would it be? It would have been about 1967? To Cambridge, and that's where he ended his, his career. But for some reason I didn't see much of him either after, until, until I was about 13. Yes, I first saw him at 13 when I went over to visit him in Belfast, and I didn't quite know what was there really. But he didn't get on well with my mother. (pp. 1-3)

2: Prejudice against Business at St Paul's

There was another thing which I found a bit disturbing about the school St Paul's]. I had a very close friend there and his family was more coming out of the business tradition, and [the school] clearly made a very sharp separation. [We began] equally well in the class together, but there came a point where he was hived off into a different stream, which was not a stream which they were very interested in. Business was sort of - there were important things like the Civil Service and academic life, but business was something which was not quite right! So you felt that they gave up on you, and then they just pushed the academically bright people. But I really felt that quite sharply because we were such close friends, and do you know I lived his experience of that, well, for him that was a sort of discrimination really.

PT: Very interesting . It says a lot of what happened to the British economy, I suppose!

DG: Absolutely! They were very explicit about it, actually. I can remember the high masters sitting and talking to us about careers and which were a service to the country. Whether through politics or through Civil Service, or through academic work, was what a career should be about. And there were these mundane careers and business careers which were not really worthy, so it was that together with, of course, the quite extraordinary elitism, "You are going to be the elite of the future, and you'd better live up to your responsibilities". (p. 7)

3: St Paul's School Connections with Oxford Colleges

Well, it was, actually I didn't have any strong views about going to university at the beginning at St. Paul's, and [not only that], then I was simply told that I was going to Oxford. I said, "Oh! Really?" "Yes!" And not only, I was told it had to be one of three colleges, so that's how – and that's where you got that division I was describing with my friend, who was told he was not going anywhere near Oxford! But it was just a sort of feel, most people were on automatic pilot, actually, and I suppose that's one of the things those schools did. They had, of course they had connections.

PT: So which were the St. Paul's colleges actually?

DG: Well, the one I went to was Magdalen, but I think they also had a link with New College and, I think Merton was perhaps the other. But actually, I visited them, and I thought Magdalen was just so beautiful, a dream. But yes, it's a very strange day when you're just told where you're going, university, and "That's all right. That's fine!" (p. 11)

4: Two Contrasting Oxford Tutors: Richard Cobb and Theodore Zeldin

I was really lucky because I had Richard Cobb for the French Revolution, and I had Theodore Zeldin for the Third Republic, and that was a wonderful combination. Two radically different people,, but both very inspirational, though… Richard believed in getting inside the characters, inside a relatively small number of characters, but living their life internally, so he captured the sort of excitement of the moment, in a sense, and the way in which people thought. He was very empathetic in his approach, and sometimes you could almost see Robespierre appear in front of you. He would link this to other stories of terror, in a way which was very powerful. His own experience, for instance, of being in Germany immediately after the War, where he explained how he could terrorise local people by offering them cigarettes, getting, these services. This sense of power that [people] had, he conveyed also through his own, through experiences. So you got this odd mixture of empathy with the historical characters, and then parts of his own biography which corresponded to it!

[He was] very interesting [about] the excitement of archives, especially chaotic archives, he hated ordered archives, so anybody who had sorted an archive out had killed it, basically! But it's when you got a letter, and then a pair of spectacles, and then another letter which wasn't supposed to be there, which actually had all the secrets in it. This was really exciting! But, of course, he did drink a lot, Richard, and sometimes the tutorials suffered from that. Once I arrived, he was just flat on the floor, he was completely unconscious, so I went away, and then he had the gall, the next week, to admonish me for not turning up for the tutorial! Scandalous! And his views could be quite extreme, actually, Richard.

But Theodore was absolutely the reverse of this. He was quite quiet, very much in control, interested in structures not individuals. He was interested in the way in which social institutions and culture were developing, so the grand figures played a much smaller role. But you did get an excitement - I think the best tutorial I ever had with him was the one on Debussy. I went into his study in St. Antony's, and he said, "You know, the only way to really get to know Debussy is to hear him".

So he put on a record of *Pelléas and Mélisande* for the entire tutorial! That was wonderful! I'd never heard any Debussy! But I thought this was absolutely magical and I fell in love with Debussy. And we talked about him a bit more at the next tutorial. So he could certainly convey his enthusiasms too. But he was very much more analytic than Richard.

It was a very very good balance, I think, of types of ways, to get two very different ways of doing history, both of which have got great qualities I think. Both of them, of course, detested each other, and Richard was very abusive about Theodore, saying, "There's no blood in the man, you know! He doesn't capture the emotion, but what is history about? How people lived life emotionally. His stuff is dead!" And then Theodore would say, "Well, he just picks on these odd characters, he writes them up, but we don't know whether this was very typical of what was going on. "But what about all the other people?" … They were quite severe about each other, but I think, for a student, that was wonderful, that was really good. (pp. 13-14)

5: LSE, Another Culture

I entered LSE, and just, everything was on fire about the Vietnam War. This was really quite strange, because there were quite a lot of Americans who had not gone out to fight in Vietnam, but had come to LSE to study, and they felt very passionately about it. I remember what seemed to be very strange discussions with them about the Viet Cong who were shackled to their machine guns, and they were saying this showed how brave they were. And I would say, "Well, are you sure this is bravery? I mean, if you're, with this constraint -" and they would get very angry. So it was very very passionate. I felt I was a real marginal character there, in terms of the political enthusiasms of it. Of course, it is a bit contagious! I certainly moved a long way there, but not into active political radicalism…

No, I suppose I was really a rather puzzled naïve person particularly watching this extraordinary surge of emotion and political concern at LSE. But meanwhile, of course, the classes all fell apart, so eventually they didn't exist at all! Although [Donald] MacRae used to invite me for tutorials in Euston Station, in the bar, which was a continuation of the way in which he gave tutorials, with a large glass of whisky, and it was very noisy in the bar, but basically, the alcohol consumption was quite similar I think! But the tutorials were a bit folkloric. I'm not sure that I really regarded them quite as tutorials as I'd known them in Oxford. They weren't that tightly focused on the academic subject. (p. 18)

6: History and Sociology

Well, in Oxford history, you did countries country by country, and there's a point where you'd done Britain, and then you were doing France, 19th century, and there were quite important similarities in what's going on. Here too, people seem to be moving out into factories, but there was no attempt to explain why there were these commonalities between countries. So I really [wanted] to find out more about that, why it is that they share these structural changes, and discussing with people, and Basil [Bernstein], of course, sociology seemed to offer that, in the sense that it was a study of types of society rather than individual societies.

Then, of course, when I started studying sociology at LSE, I think it was the other side, my history was always there, so when they were talking about generalisations about societies, I was talking about the distinctiveness of the experiences rooted in past historical paths. That's always been a tension throughout my work, and my interests. It's not tension in a sense, something uncomfortable, it's been an interesting intellectual issue for me, of how far you can explain things in terms of, say, common properties of capitalist societies, or industrial societies, as against the effects of long-term national paths of development and historical experiences. One of the things that amazed me in studying sociology at LSE was that you would have lots of theories of social change, but they were all based upon internal processes within societies, and war never came up. [There] was no idea that societies could be completely transformed because they'd been invaded! So it was all looking at the internal dynamics of how any particular society developed. But coming from history, that was really quite strange. (p. 17)

7: Contexts of Sociability or its Absence: LSE, Essex and Warwick

Well, actually, I was in the relationship with Martine [his future wife]. I didn't spend that much time with fellow students, and of course, LSE was closed for part of this [year]. And LSE isn't a place where you get to know people very easily, because everybody disperses after the classes, actually, to go back to different parts of London, [at least in those] those days, so there's nobody I really got to know well and stayed closely in contact with over time. Although we would go out to the pub together, and we would chat, and we would have these long discussions about Vietnam and issues, so I enjoyed the company there, but I don't think it was as - I think that was partly LSE, you didn't have the benefits of the dinners of Oxford Colleges, or even [the social life] of Essex, at LSE. I think

people who were on the staff there, they felt the same thing, they'd go off to Hampstead, and one would go off to West London - there wasn't that amount of closeness of after life though there. (p. 20)

[Being appointed at Essex] led to some of my happiest years I think. It was very much a convivial Essex at that time, and people invited me round to parties, which was great fun. But there was also very serious intellectual discussion, and, yes, it was going for lunch with senior [academics] – Peter Townsend, David Lockwood, Tony Atkinson, Michael Mann round the table, and discussing – it was really a learning experience, and quite fun to see the repartee too, of David Lockwood saying to Peter, "Well, you know, your work is of no theoretical interest whatsoever", and Peter replying, "And yours is of no practical interest either!" But there we are! I think one learnt a lot through that.

I was always a bit marginal to the Department because I was put on to teaching the joint courses, I taught with Bob Jessop, politics and sociology. Bob was deep into Althusserian and Poulantzian theory, which I must say, I spent a lot of time struggling with, but what I could understand I really didn't feel was quite right, so we tended to disagree a lot in the classes, and that eventually led to trouble. I was called in by Stan Cohen who told me that students were complaining that the lecturers were disagreeing about the origins of Fascism, and they were unhappy about this. It's a bit sad, really! That reflected, I think, changing student attitudes across the seventies.

But the other person that I taught with, Paul, the other course om which I taught was the Social Policy Course, with Adrian, Adrian Sinfield, and I learnt a lot from that. Of course, Adrian was into unemployment research at the time, and that truly had an influence. I think both Peter and Adrian had an influence on my later work thinking about the Initiative, because that's where I, discussing with Peter you inevitably familiarised yourself with issues of poverty and disadvantage, income disadvantage, and Adrian really introduced me to the unemployment literature, so that all proved very, very valuable later. And I just enjoyed Essex so much.

Going to Warwick was a bit, it was a much colder sort of place… Warwick, of course, was much more polarised. It was a very unhappy Department when I arrived because of the very intense conflicts between John Rex and the people he'd appointed, and I think, in a sense it's very nice to be able to appoint 15 people in such a short period of time, but it does run a risk which is that you think of yourself as the "father of the Department" and these are your children, and you find it very difficult to move away from that, and when they start developing theoretical approaches you don't agree with, you get rather angry. I think this is what happened to John. John, of course, was one of the founders of conflict theory in sociology, [but] he certainly didn't agree with the neo-Marxist [approach] which, of course, became the predominant sort of thinking of people like Simon Clarke, Tony Elgar and so on. So he didn't like this challenge from the Left at all – or what came to be a challenge from the Left

– and there'd obviously been a civil war in this Department, and John was not on speaking terms with anybody else…

I think the outcome of that tension between John and the Department also probably coincided with the family cycle of people. So when I was there [at Essex], not many people had children, which made the sociability much easier than when we had children, actually, lots of people were free and open, open to accept invitations at the last minute. In Warwick, I think people were going back home and looking after their children more, so it was a Department where people ate sandwiches in their rooms at lunch time, rather than have these debates I was talking about between Peter Townsend and David, and so on. (pp. 50-3)

8: Religious Distinctions

My great-uncle was a priest, so I did go, as a child, when on holidays, to the church. But my mother was a very fierce agnostic, and the crunch time came when I came to St. Paul's, because St. Paul's had a very simple system. Most people were Church of England and they went to the big service at the beginning of the day. And then there was a Jewish quota. My mother said, "You're not going to the Church of England Services. It's not possible. You should just sit somewhere quietly and work". And she rang them up in the middle of a Wagner opera at Covent Garden, to tell them that this was absolutely her firm view and there was no way that she was going to allow this. But they found an ingenious solution, which was to put me with the Jewish quota, so they hid away in a little room above the school theatre during the Service time. So all my friends in St. Paul's were actually Jewish, because this is where I met the other people – which was quite a curious thing! … The School was so inflexible, it had no ability to make any other sort of distinction. But I was very happy with the solution! It wasn't quite what my mother had expected!

PT: So did they happen to be an interesting group of pupils?

DG: Yes, I suppose so. Well, they were really the brightest of the classes. They were certainly great fun and very rich, culturally. One of my closest friends [was the son of] an art dealer, and I'd go for meals at his flat, and there'd be a Braque across the wall just in front of [me], by the dinner table, and

so on, which was very lovely. And again, opera was very important in that milieu. So in some senses it was a good outcome I think. (pp. 21-22)

9: Encountering Inequality

In a sense, there are a set of experiences which I think sensitised me to problems of inequality, and that was probably this passage through these very different schools I was describing yesterday, from having experienced, really, very much a working-class London school, and then ending up in St. Paul's, which I suppose was about one of the most privileged schools you could possibly be in. So I'd really seen the spectrum of schools and it made you aware of the differences in life chances that were linked to that.

But another set of experiences which I think made me particularly interested in work, was going to, the first was when I went to India at the age of 13 – my mother had this view that I should experience the world early, and sent me on my own to be met by somebody in India, and this person turned out to run a tea plantation in Assam. Well, first of all I spent some time wandering around Calcutta because I wasn't met as I was supposed to be met at the airport, and that, of course, was a terrific shock – the poverty in Calcutta, with the refugees that had come down after the sort of Chinese engagement in Northern Assam. But then the tea plantation was run in the most brutal way. It was very much an authoritarian regime where the owners treated the people on the plantations as really sort of semi-slaves, as far as I could see. I can remember there was one incident where I was in the Jeep with them, driving down one of these small alleys between the tea bushes, and there were a group of people – women, children, men – chatting in the, in this alley, and he just drove up, he increased the speed as he approached them. He said, "Oh, they'll jump out of the way!" So that was very striking, and it made me aware of just how people who have got a lot of power can be quite vicious in the way they use it.

Then, of course, I'd previously had the experience at this prep school that I mentioned to you, which was also run on very authoritarian grounds, so I think I was very interested to go to a kibbutz where I'd heard that there was a much more democratic culture of how you ran an organisation. One of my Jewish friends had a contact with a person called Greville Janner – you may have heard of him - who ran an organisation called "The Bridge" in Britain, and he was very very well-connected, he organised this. I did, first of all, a tour through Syria and Jordan, but ended up in Israel, going to this kibbutz, where I spent about a month really, and that was a very interesting experience. I think there was a much higher level of real democracy within the organisation than you'd find in most other work organisations, but it wasn't perfect, it wasn't totally pure because the elders had quite a say, which was

a sort of informal [group] of the elders, which was quite powerful. But it was also very interesting from the point of view of the children, the way they brought up children, who were still, at that time, collectively brought up. The mothers put them into a collective centre, I think in their third month. What was interesting there was, [that] in a sense, they were all convinced that this was very good for the children, that it broke them away from dependence on their parents, and made them tougher sorts of people as well. But the mothers couldn't stand it. So they were going to demolish this, and I think they did after I'd left, because they said it was too emotionally difficult for the mothers. So that was quite an interesting experience…

So, yes, quite a lot of my work has been about problems of power structures in organisations, and the opportunities for people to participate in decisions that matter to their lives, and certainly I think this was quite an important sort of influence on my thinking of that.

I don't think I've ever found an organisation, apart from Nuffield College, which runs as democratically as a kibbutz! (pp. 22-24)

10: Gaining Access to Oil Refineries through an Oxford Connection

I was able to get the access because my College Tutor in St. Antony's had some connection with the oil industry. He said, "Oh, I know somebody in BP. Why don't you go and have a chat to them?" So I went down to London, to their skyscraper. They seemed quite happy with it. It eventually took nine months to get the permission to have access, when I decided that my first refinery to work in was Dunkerque. I went over in a boat, on a very very stormy night, everybody was being sick and plates were falling off the dinner tables and so on! And I was met there by the General Secretary. But it again took two weeks before they would allow me to start interviewing. Of course, we were in the period after May '68, and students weren't looked on particularly in a favourable way – either by management or by the Unions – so the refinery manager said, "Well, if you start going in and try to interview, we'll have a riot, It'll just be a riot". So anyhow, I chatted to the Union officials over a couple of weeks, and finally persuaded [the refinery manager] to allow me to go in for eight hours. This was pretty short because I wanted to do 200 interviews!

But he gave me this sort of leeway. He said, "Look, if there's no trouble in the first eight hours I'll extend it a bit", and we worked on this basis. I went in, and there was no trouble at all. And then he extended it to a week, and then two weeks, and after that it was okay with the, the other French refinery, because the news had gone through that I didn't create riots! The British refineries,

of course, were much easier, and I didn't really have any, any difficulty getting the permissions to go into those. But they had much better industrial relations! (pp. 24-25)

11: Comparing British and French Trade Unions in the Oil Refineries

I started from the fact that a lot of the literature in what was then Industrial Sociology, was premised on the view that technology was the main driver of social relations at work, the nature of the work task and social relations at work, and including the relations with management. So whether you looked at the French literature or the British literature, or the American literature, this was a common assumption. But coming at it from my historical background, I suspected that things weren't quite like this, and that there would be different types of authority styles at least, which derived from different historical backgrounds. So that's what I was exploring really, which of these types of hypotheses was right. Was it this dominant idea that technology drove the nature of the work, or were there was important cultural differences that were still prevalent? Which of these was more powerful? Well, in a sense the most advanced technological sector at the time seemed to be a rather good test of that because a lot of the literature said, "Well, if there had been differences in the past with automation, all these will be ironed out." …

And so it proved to be that though you'd got a single company – I mean, it was BP in both countries – with almost identical refineries, we still found the way in which they were managed, and the way in which work was organised, was quite different. Tasks were more similar, I mean, the actual nature of everyday work tasks, but the management structure and the overall work organisation, the sort of incentives that people were given, the way they were controlled, were quite different. And I suppose everything really followed from that. That bit remained a very dominant interest right up to my most recent books, and exploring that.

I know you say that there was an important contrast in the character of the Unions, and the way they behaved. Could you explain that a bit? .

Yes. In so far as the British were very similar to the sort of picture you get from Allan Flander's work on productivity negotiations and so on, so there was quite a high level of co-operation, and it's almost complicity actually between shop stewards and management. I mean, you know, they were

concerned, the Union was very concerned about pay, right? But they were not making much in the way of claims about how management should organise things, but insofar as there were problems in the refinery, the idea was to iron them out, and many of these stewards were later promoted, became foremen and so on. So the British promotion structure was relatively fluid in those days. So there was quite a close co-operation there.

In France it was extremely conflictual, because the Unions had a legal right to present themselves, and they came in, in diverse forms, with ideologies! And the most powerful of the Unions was the CGT which was, at that time, quite strongly controlled by the French Communist Party, and it came with a very radical ideology. But it wasn't on it's own. The CFDT at that time was developing a sort of "autogestionaire" ideology which meant that it, too, was contesting the ideas of management being in control. So you had both the radical contestation of the idea of management having authoritarian power in France, but also it's this extraordinary division between the unions, and rivalry, which meant that their strikes tended to fail, because if the CGT called out its workers on strike, the CFDT thought, "Well, I'm not sure we want to join this and give all the credits to the CGT, and vice-versa.

So you had a radical rhetoric but a lack of efficacy, whereas in Britain I think although relations were generally co-operative, if the Unions decided to go out on strike, that really counted. I mean, they could bring the refinery to a halt. It hasn't happened often, but they had [a strike] in Grangemouth, which was the Scottish refinery, after my study. So the rhetoric there was low-keyed, but the power was substantial. (pp. 28-29)

12: Current Methodological Problems

Sociology is running into some methodological difficulty because with surveys we have a major problem with response rates, which have been going steadily down. In the studies in the 1980s I could get a 75% response rate. You can't get that any more.

But case studies, especially in the area of work, have also run into difficulty, which is that access has become very difficult. I'm involved, currently, in a European project looking at the implications of the quality of work, for innovation productivity, and the British team has had enormous difficulty getting in anywhere. You're very far from the days when the Industrial Relations Research Unit had access to a wide range of factories around Coventry, and people like Eric Batstone could study them for long periods of time in great detail and so on. It's now very difficult to get in

even for very short interviews. So I don't think there's been a lot of very exciting case study work, the reason is it's been very very difficult to get the access, and I don't see that improving.

It's related, I think, to two things. One is that Union power has receded, and, of course, a lot of the access was actually secured with Union co-operation, and where management has pretty well total prerogative it's proved more difficult. But also the work regimes have tightened up. I was in one extreme part of the spectrum with oil refineries in that people had quite a lot of time at work. But basically time has been squeezed out in work situations, so you can't easily, in the current work regimes, find [the time to interview] – if you go into a factory, people are working [all the day]. And the managers are making sure they are, there isn't time off. And breaks and so on have all been eroded, so it's much much more difficult to do this sort of work.

PT: So you have to really interview people outside the factory.

DG: You'd have to interview them outside, which is again difficult because it's very difficult to get the sampling frame. So there are problems! (pp. 35-6)

13: Learning Longitudinal Data Analysis

So it was a very, very stimulating collaboration, and my sense is that most people enjoyed – not everybody – but most people enjoyed it, and felt that they learnt a lot, and they learnt a lot both substantively, and substantively, but also in terms of methodology, because not many people had done survey work at that time, and we were all learning, we were running very fast to keep up with the thing, especially longitudinal data analysis. Even at its best it was pretty primitive in those days. We invited Uli Mayer to talk about the way he did it, and he showed us these spaghetti diagrams, which made your mind just whirl with how you could interpret the stuff. But basically, Peter Elias was really very important there, he explained we could make some sense of providing programmes for that, and Richard Davies was also writing programmes to enable the work history analysis, and he gave us basically team project courses on longitudinal data a

nalysis. (p. 39)

14: Labour Segmentation

This idea is that labour markets aren't an open system whereby people get the rewards that their skills might deserve, and they basically apply across any sector of the labour market, rather that people get trapped in particular sectors which have very different conditions. In some versions this develops into a notion of a core where you get cumulative advantage and a periphery where you get cumulative disadvantage, and then people get trapped in there for a variety of reasons, and they tend to be more vulnerable either because they're new to the labour market, they're young, or women coming into work for the first time, or because they've experienced unemployment. And one of the issues that started coming out of the initiative was that unemployment was not just a short-term experience, actually, but rolled on in people's lives. Peter Warr's work was always relatively short-term, so what he demonstrated, very clearly, was that unemployment had very severe psychological consequences for people, but on the whole, if they got back into work, that diminished fairly quickly. But what we were able to show with work histories and so on was that, actually, people were marked for a long time, because the sort of jobs that they were getting were jobs which made them more vulnerable to become unemployed later. So they were obviously happy, much happier, when they got back to work, but they were also in a much more fragile situation in the longer term. So those are the sort of issues in the labour market segmentation debate. How rigid those barriers are between core and periphery, how much cumulative disadvantage there is, or is it actually a more fragmented picture with some groups being disadvantaged in particular ways, and others in other ways? And it was a very fruitful approach, I think. Yes. There was a lot of thinking and new ideas. (p. 47)

15: Raising Survey Funds from Business

But I managed to realise the National Survey afterwards, and the funding of that was very peculiar because a third of it was actually funded by industry, and that was the easiest funding I've ever managed to find. It started with a dinner time conversation with Alistair Graham who was then running the Industrial Society, and I said, "Well, you know, I really want to do this, this national survey". He was here in Nuffield for dinner. [He told me] "I think Bryan Nicholson would be quite interested" - he was running the Manpower Services Commission – and Alastair and Bryan collected 30 industrialists around a dinner in London, and I gave a 20 minute chat on the project, and then he said, "Well, it would be nice if you could get out your cheques." And he collected some initial cheques and promises for future money for this thing.

It was explained to me afterwards it was actually, the critical thing was the amount you asked for, that the heads of Personnel Departments, or Human Resource Managements, had some sort of authority to make payments up to about £30,000. So nobody questioned that sort of thing, as long as you convinced them that you were doing something worthwhile, and there was a relevance to things important to them. Alistair Graham also gave me a very good tip, which I think everybody should know about when they're doing this sort of work, which is that if you're going for private funding like that company funding, always get a lot of companies involved, because if you just go for one and they fund it, you're very much under their dependence. If you go for 30 and just say you get 20, they will never agree on a common position about anything in terms of what the survey should look like, so basically, as an academic you have quite a lot of autonomy, or total autonomy. And that proved to be the case, actually, the firms played no role in actually organising the project, or put no constraints on it, made a very useful contribution.

So we got that, but then the, the big problem was to get [the rest of the funding] – that paid for about half of the survey, and I'd very much hoped that the ESRC would pay for the other half as a sort of continuation of this national survey, but they weren't interested in it. Dear George Bain went and defended this in front of Council, he said it was scandalous, and when industry had given all this money, the ESRC was so thoughtless, uninterested in the impact of social research, that it was not prepared to pay the other half. There was no way they would do it.

But Leverhulme came up and they paid the other half. So we got the funding for that.

(pp. 48-9)